

OUTSIDE HELP

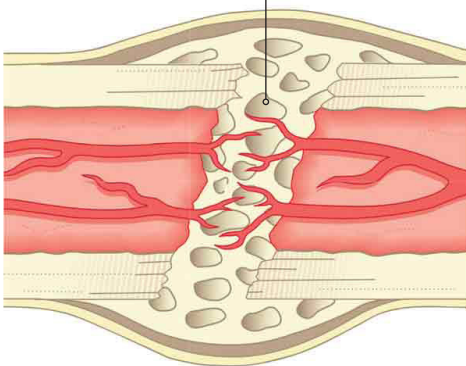


Broken bone ends are usually held together in the right position to make sure they heal correctly. This is often done using a rigid **plaster cast**.



For more severe fractures, **pins** are used to keep the bones lined up. This X-ray shows pinned leg bones just above the ankle.

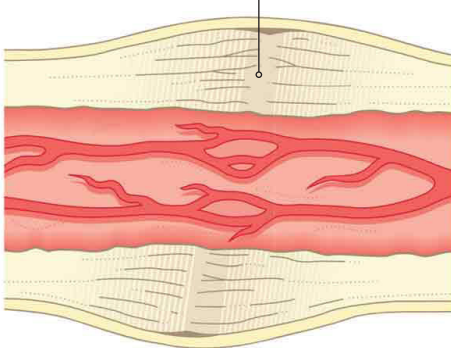
Spongy bone forms between the bone ends



THREE WEEKS LATER

Bone-building cells are now active. They weave a mesh of spongy bone that provides a bond between the bone ends. But the bone is still weak and would be set in a plaster cast.

Hard **compact bone** replaces the spongy bone



THREE MONTHS LATER

Blood vessels reconnect across the break. The healed bone shaft, made of compact bone, is almost the same shape as it was before the fracture.